# Who's Covering What for Dad?

A guide to the family conversation, starting with the one who fills in.

Your sister stops by Dad's most evenings. She has never listed everything she does there, and it has never come up. The care plan has its list, the agency has its schedule, and her part isn't written anywhere.

This guide is for one conversation with one job: get everyone's part of Dad's week onto one page, and agree who will ask about the lines nobody is sure of. It isn't for deciding whether his care is working.

## Who should be there

Your sister, and Dad if he'd like to be part of it. It's his care, and his account of how the help is going belongs on the page in his own words. Then everyone else who helps or visits: the brother who comes on Sundays, the neighbor who brings the mail in. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests including everyone who is or will be part of the caregiving team, which may mean a family friend or a neighbor as well as relatives. [1]

Someone who can't come can send notes ahead. Pick one person to take notes, and let it be someone other than your sister. She'll be doing a lot of the talking.

## How to open

Start by asking, not by reporting what you've found. The National Institute on Aging suggests checking in with the older person and the other caregivers regularly, to make sure the current arrangement is still working for everyone. [2]

- “You're there more than any of us. Before we look at the plan, could you walk us through a usual week?”
- “Dad, we'd like to hear how the help is going from where you sit.”
- Say what the conversation is for: one page showing who covers what. Say what it isn't for: checking up on anyone, or changing anything about Dad's care.

## Questions to ask

## Ask your sister, or whoever fills in

1. What do you do for Dad that the rest of us probably don't know about?

2. Is any of it something you understood the agency, or one of us, would be doing?

3. Which part is hardest to keep up, and is there any part you'd rather hand to someone else?

## Ask Dad

1. Which parts of the help suit you, and which would you like done differently?

2. Who do you see in a usual week, and is there anything you'd like more of?

## Ask each other

1. What have you seen for yourself, and what are you going on from the schedule or from what someone told you?

2. Where does what you've seen differ from the plan, or from what someone else here has seen?

3. What don't any of us know yet, and who could tell us?

## How to write down what was said

Write each open item plainly, as something to check and not as something that went wrong. Keep Dad's own account separate from the family's. Where two people remember it differently, write both and don't settle it. If everyone heard the same thing from the same person, that's one account, not three.

| WHAT'S COVERED, OR OPEN | WHO SAID IT | SEEN OR TOLD, AND WHEN | WHO WILL ASK, AND WHOM |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Supper most evenings, and laundry on Saturdays. Not on any schedule.** | Karen | She does it herself | |
| **“The aide reminds him about his pills.”** | The care plan | Told. None of us has been there for it. | David will ask the agency scheduler |
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## What not to decide yet

Some of these wait on calls you haven't made yet, and some need a professional who assesses Dad. Leave them open.

- Whether the agency, or anyone else, is doing what they said they would.

- Whether Dad is safe.
- Whether to change his care, his schedule or who provides it.
- Who was right.
- Anything about his medications.

## What you can decide today

- Who will write up the notes and send them to everyone.
- Who will ask about each open item, and who they'll ask: the agency, the nurse, his doctor or your care consultant.
- When you'll talk again.

**What this guide doesn't do**

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, say whether Dad's care is working, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets your family to one page, with your sister's week on it and the open items left open.

### Ready for the next step?

Your family has one page now, with your sister's week and Dad's own account on it, and a name beside each open item. The care interview takes that page through Dad's situation area by area so nothing important is overlooked, and turns it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

**Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›**

**WHERE THIS COMES FROM**


1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
2. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities